

Diploma in Leadership & Management

# How to be strategic



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## Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of strategic thinking and planning. The student will also be able to approach time management with a new point of view which will allow them to better manage their time.

## Introduction

Strategic thinking and development come up a lot in business, managers and leaders are expected to be strategic when approaching different aspects of the company. But strategic thinking, planning and goal creation needs to be taught for managers and leaders to excel in this department. This lesson gives you the tools and insight when it comes to thinking and planning in a strategic manner. After that, we focus on time management as part of your strategic approach. Strategic thinking and planning does not work if you do not have the capability to get the job done.

## Key reading materials:

- <https://trainingindustry.com/articles/professional-development/how-you-can-sharpen-your-strategic-thinking-skills/>
- **Practical example:** [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q5Djl9\\_Xc3w](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q5Djl9_Xc3w)
- **Podcasts:** <https://player.fm/podcasts/Strategic-Thinking>

## Key skills needed for strategic thinking

According to (direction, n.d.), strategic thinking is a process that defines the manner in which people think about, assess, view, and create the future for themselves and others. Strategic thinking is an extremely effective and valuable tool. One can apply strategic thinking to arrive at decisions that can be related to your work or personal life. Strategic thinking involves developing an entire set of critical skills. What are those critical skills?

The following are key strategic thinking skills to have:

### Your brain

There is a need for you to use both the right and left side of your brain. You need to be logical but also use the creative side of your brain when looking at a problem. When you are able to use both sides of your brain, you'll be more effective at coming up with dynamic and complex solutions that effectively solve any problem.

### Vision

Vision is so important. You need to have a clearly defined personal and business vision to create purpose. Having your purpose means that you will be able to focus more effectively.

### Communication

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### Benchmarks

Create benchmarks of what needs to be achieved and by when. This will allow you to have critical points in your planning and thinking. When you reach those benchmarks, you can either stay on your current course or you can be flexible enough to change as needed.

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## Commitment to learning

Learning needs to be part of your actions, the way you think and in the way you approach everything as a manager and leader. You need to commit to making learning a fulltime commitment. You can start this process, by taking small steps. You can ask for advice from your colleagues, you can reflect on your actions and create a strategy to improve for the future or you can focus on reading. It is up to you to select a path and then commit to it.

## Perspective

Control your perspective. Great managers and leaders avoid judging prematurely and making quick decisions without looking at the big picture. When it comes to strategic thinking, the same applies. You must look at the situation or problem from all angles to see what is happening. Avoid allowing your own bias in the situation.

## Ways to improve your thinking

According to (Bowman, n.d.) it's important that those decisions are made in a rational, level-headed state of mind, weighing all the options fairly. Carefully-honed strategic thinking skills are imperative to the profitability, growth, and general success of a business. Taking the time to hone those skills is time well spent. At CMOE we offer experiential training to improve strategic thinking skills in business to ensure your company will stand tall in today's ever-changing business world. Next up, here are some ways to improve your strategic thinking.

### Reflect

The Harvard Business Review puts it this way: "Strategic people create connections between ideas, plans and people that others fail to see." But how can you possibly make those connections if you never give your mind the chance to see them? In other words, the first clue about how to think strategically is also the first word in the phrase. You need to think. And that means making a commitment to slow down and let your mind turn things over.

Make time during the way where you can spend time to think. Take into account your most productive times of the day. For example, some people work better in the morning hours, while others need time in the evening. You need to take note of your natural time schedule and use that to plan.

### Broaden your perspective:

The more you know, the more exposure you receive, the better your strategic thinking becomes. Strategic thinking and curiosity go hand in hand. After all, the more ideas and experiences we're exposed to, the more material we have to make connections with. The most effective way to do this is to step out from behind your desk when you can and start experiencing the world: try to experience new things, new places and new people. Take those holidays you've been saving up for, visit that gallery you've been meaning to. Even taking a different route home or visiting a new park or restaurant can help stimulate the mind.

### Get others involved

The more strategic thinkers and planners you have around you, the better. The idea is to create a company and team culture that values and promotes strategic thinking. You can help and encourage your team to think more strategically by assigning a mentor, project and use that process to help guide them.

## Strategic planning process

Please note that this process is provided by (Onstrategy, n.d.).

### Getting Started: Introduction

The strategic management process is about getting from Point A to Point B more effectively, efficiently, and enjoying the journey and learning from it. Part of that journey is the strategy and part of it is execution. Having a good strategy dictates "how" you travel the road you have selected and effective execution makes sure you are checking in along the way. On average, this process can take between three and four months. However no one organization is alike and you may decide to fast track your process or slow it down. Move at a pace that works best for you and your team and leverage this as a

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resource. For more of a deep dive look into each part of the planning phase, you will see a link to the detailed How-To Guide at the top of each phase.

## Phase duration

1-2 weeks (1 hr meeting with Owner/CEO, Strategy Director and Facilitator (if necessary) to discuss information collected and direction for the continued strategic planning.)

Questions to Ask:

- Who is on your Planning Team?
- Who will be the business process owner (Strategy Director) of strategic planning in your organization?
- Fast forward 12 months from now, what do you want to see differently in your organization as a result of embarking on this initiative?

Outcome:

- Planning team members are informed of their roles and responsibilities.
- Planning schedule is established.
- Existing planning information and secondary data collected.

## Step 1: Determine Organizational Readiness

Set up Your Planning Process for Success – Questions to Ask:

- Are the conditions and criteria for successful planning in place at the current time? Can certain pitfalls be avoided?
- Is this the appropriate time for your organization to initiate a planning process? Yes or no? If no, where do you go from here?

## Step 2: Develop Your Team & Schedule

Who is going to be on your strategic planning team? You need to choose someone to oversee the implementation (Chief Strategy Officer or Strategy Director) and then you need some of the key individuals and decision makers for this team. It should be a small group of approximately 12-15 persons and 18 worksheets to learn

## Step 3: Collect Current Data

Collect the following information on your organization:

- The last strategic plan, even if it is not current
- Mission statement, vision statement, values statement
- Business plan
- Financial records for the last few years
- Marketing plan
- Other information, such as last year's SWOT, sales figures and projections

## Step 4: Review collected data

Review the data collected in the last action with your strategy director and facilitator.

- What trends do you see?
- Are there areas of obvious weakness or strengths?
- Have you been following a plan or have you just been going along with the market?

## Strategic thinking exercises:

Please note that the exercises are provided by (Brainzooming, n.d.)

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## Strategic Thinking Exercise: Simulation and Role Playing

### Challenge #1 – Extrapolating from Today:

Romano stresses the futility of imagining a car charging model by extrapolating from the current auto fueling one. The key is to experience (or imagine the experience of) driving an electric vehicle with its differing needs.

### Strategic Thinking Exercise:

Create an interactive, day-in-the-life scenario to imagine the future. Do the homework upfront via research, forward-looking case studies, immersing users in prototypes or virtual reality experiences, and simulating the future ahead. Providing a robust future view helps people more thoroughly envision it for your audiences and organisation.

Participants will take on roles as future audience members. Within the role playing, they will brainstorm specific questions, challenges, opportunities, and behaviours they will encounter. This lets participants envision a typical future day unfolding sequentially.

It's not unusual for brainstorming exercises to stipulate that every starting idea is good. To help future-imagining Brainzooming participants detach from today as much as possible, we anticipate one person steeped in the forward-looking research taking on a unique role: Owner of the Future. This person will listen for present-day thinking that no longer applies, in the future. If they hear speculation inconsistent with the future, they'll exclaim loudly, "The future doesn't work like that!" Yes, the role is different. Played by the right person, we think it will lighten things up and focus ideas.

## Strategic Thinking Exercise: Flipping Minimal and Abundant

### Challenge #2 – Emerging Events Seem Microscopic:

Before the next major event becomes major, it has minimal impact. Maybe 1% of the next big thing will be apparent while the status quo accounts for 99% of what we experience. At some point in the future, whatever the next big thing is will account for the overwhelming majority of instances, but not immediately.

### Strategic Thinking Exercise:

Quantify statistics about the current status quo and emerging situations, using them in an exercise where you flip the numbers. Associate the minimal numbers of the emerging development with the abundant numbers of the status quo, and vice versa. Once you blatantly reset the future view through a number flip, have participants imagine the future by asking:

- What will be important for success in this scenario?
- How will audience member expectations change?
- Who else would want to become a supplier or supporter in this scenario?
- What new opportunities could develop with so many things flipped versus today?
- What new problems might emerge with many things the opposite of now?

## Strategic Thinking Exercise: Constrain Thinking to a Completely Technological Future

### Challenge #3 – Thinking Technology Impacts Will Come Up Short:

As we conduct future-looking research, several things are clear: digital availability, automation, robotics, artificial intelligence, and the Internet of Things are all super-charging forward.

### Strategic Thinking Exercise:

While maybe not EVERYTHING will be digitized and automated, for the sake of imagining the future, you can comfortably say everything will be. Stipulating an all-digital future enables questions that make it more difficult to hold a today-centric perspective. Ask:

- If a function is completely digital, with no human intervention, what will it mean for audiences? How will we provide our product or service in relevant ways?
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- If every object/thing can report what it thinks / knows / senses, how will that change how other things act? What will it mean for robots? For humans? What will the object / thing do with the information to learn and improve?
- If robots handle that function (and every function before and after it), how will the experience change?
- If AI continually improves the audience experience, where will it focus improvement efforts? What will humans do differently to cope or stay ahead?

## Strategic Thinking Exercise: Accessing the Excess

### Future Strategy Challenge #4 –

Dismantling What's No Longer Necessary: Romano notes that when electric vehicles predominate, there will be need for only a tiny percentage of the 168,000 gas stations in the United States currently. The impact of dismantling this excess is significant.

### Strategic Thinking Exercise:

While it is cooler to restrict future thinking to new, innovative ideas, the impact of currently valuable assets losing utility provides another path to imagining the future. Use today's abundant things you flipped earlier and ask questions about what happens with them:

- How could we retrofit them to provide value in a radically different future?
- What other replacements will develop to provide the value and utility they currently offer?
- If we blew them up and started over, what would we do with the space / materials / resources / time they now occupy?

## Time management tools:

Please note that the following reviews are provided by, (Leis, n.d.)

### Asana

Asana combines elements of project management, file storage, and collaboration, and helps to manage projects across a team without email.

### Top features

- Break your work down into tasks, and assign it to team members
- Organize your tasks into projects for roadmaps and timelines
- Review milestones, and check on your team's progress
- Get notified about projects updates
- Use project dashboards to get a quick overview

### What's special about this tool:

Asana is a really easy-to-use tool with a simple layout. If you're a small team with not too complex projects, check it out.

**Price:** Free for up to 15 members, Premium from \$8.33 user/month

### Trello

Trello is known for visualizing project tasks on a cardboard-like dashboard that's great for managing short and quick everyday assignments.

### Top features

- Simple task management on a cardboard
  - Creating unlimited task lists
  - Image and file sharing
  - Organising lists by dates or priority
  - Commenting and collaboration
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## What's special about this tool:

From startups to Fortune 500 companies, Trello is the most visual way for teams to collaborate on any project.

**Pricing:** Free for personal use, \$9.99 user/month for businesses

## Proofhub

ProofHub is a versatile project management system used by leading organizations like NASA, Disney, Taco Bell and many more. This all-in-one tool comes packed with powerful features to eliminate the need of having too many different tools to run your business.

## Top features

- Online proofing software saves a lot of time during the feedback-sharing process
- Makes task-management less stressful for teams
- Get a visual picture of projects using Gantt charts in ProofHub
- Also available as a mobile app for Android and iOS users.

**Pricing:** From \$45/month

## Clairzen

Clarizen's cloud-based project management software has a single goal: to help move your business forward.

## Top features

- Unlimited number of projects
- Automated and repeatable processes, alerts and workflows
- Social collaboration
- Budget tracking & expense management

## What's special about this tool:

Clarizen offers configurable workflows – customize Clarizen to fit how your enterprise does business, not the opposite

**Pricing:** From \$60 user/month

## Toggl

Toggl is a no-hassle time tracking software that integrates with tens of different project management systems. It is the perfect add-on to your existing tools, helping you to be more productive throughout the day

## Top features

- Unlimited projects and sub-projects for accurate time tracking
  - Reports featuring team progress
  - Online & offline time tracking
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## What's special about this tool:

Toggl integrates seamlessly with your favourite productivity tools such as Trello, Scoro, or Asana.

**Pricing:** From \$9 user/month

## References

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